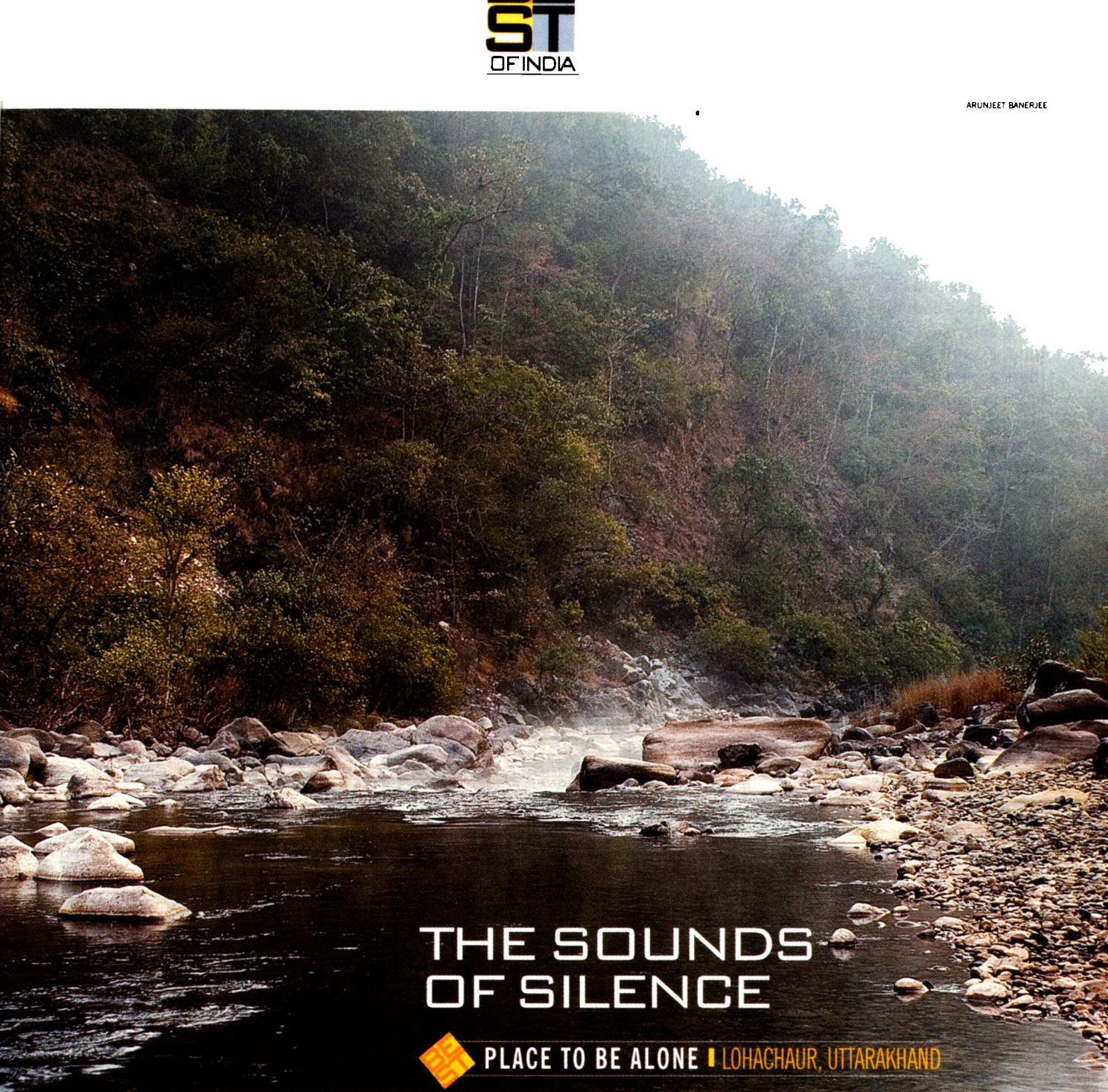




THE SOUNDS OF SILENCE



PLACE TO BE ALONE ■ LOHACHAUR, UTTARAKHAND

CALLS OF
BARKING DEER
AND SAMBHAR
RESOUND.
THERE IS NO
ELECTRICITY,
NO CELL
PHONE,
NO TELEVISION,
JUST YOU AND
THE JUNGLE.

Noise is unheard of here. Hugged by the Mandal range of mountains in Jim Corbett Tiger Reserve, Lohachaur (iron grassland) on the Reserve's north-east is a long way from the cacophony of the regular tourist fare of Ramnagar and Dhikala. Calls of barking deer and sambhar and the gurgle of the sparkling river Mandal resound in the dense sal forests that engulf the earth and the sky. There is no electricity, no cellphone tower. The law is that of the jungle. The Lohachaur rest house is a legacy of the British, who hunted wild game here. Built in 1922, with four sprawling rooms with fireplaces, it is encircled by trenches—meant to deter elephants—on three sides, and a massive mountain stands guard at the rear. This is the land where, more than 80 years ago, hunter-turned-environmentalist Jim Corbett made his way on foot, resting on trees by night. The nights even today are busy. The dirt trail winds its way to a fresh kill, a lonesome stray cow waylaid by a tiger. As dawn breaks, the forest comes alive in a million colours, blending like an incredibly perfect jigsaw.

by Rahul Tewari